



Credit Where It's Due

Annual Department of Microbiology Address

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Vilček Professor of Molecular Pathogenesis
Chair, Department of Microbiology

September 23, 2026

NYU Grossman School of Medicine

...

"I am forced to conclude that you have acted
in a malicious and slanderous manner ...

I believe that your actions **require**
a legal response on my part."

...

**This email, circa 2003, comprises
the first page of my thesis.**

This Is Not a Story About a Hard Advisor

Many of us trained under someone demanding. That is not what this was.



He scheduled people who started the same year to present back-to-back, so the room could see "who was underperforming".

Every year he had a round table lab meeting that began with telling us how much each of us had spent and then asked us to account for it.

He created a culture where saying an experiment hadn't worked meant deciding whether the answer was worth the week that followed.

Here Is What I Actually Remember

Not him. The people in the lab who were in it with me.

When I couldn't make it to the lab, there was always someone willing to move my research forward.

What we had in common was not a project. It was a problem — and it made us useful to each other.

Three of them I still talk to. One of them read this slide before you did.

**He wasn't the gift.
They were.**

Hard Circumstances Don't Deserve the Credit

Both things are true at once, and keeping them separate is the whole point.

The adversity was real.

It was damaging, it was unwanted, and no one should have had to go through it. It does not become retroactively good because something survived it.

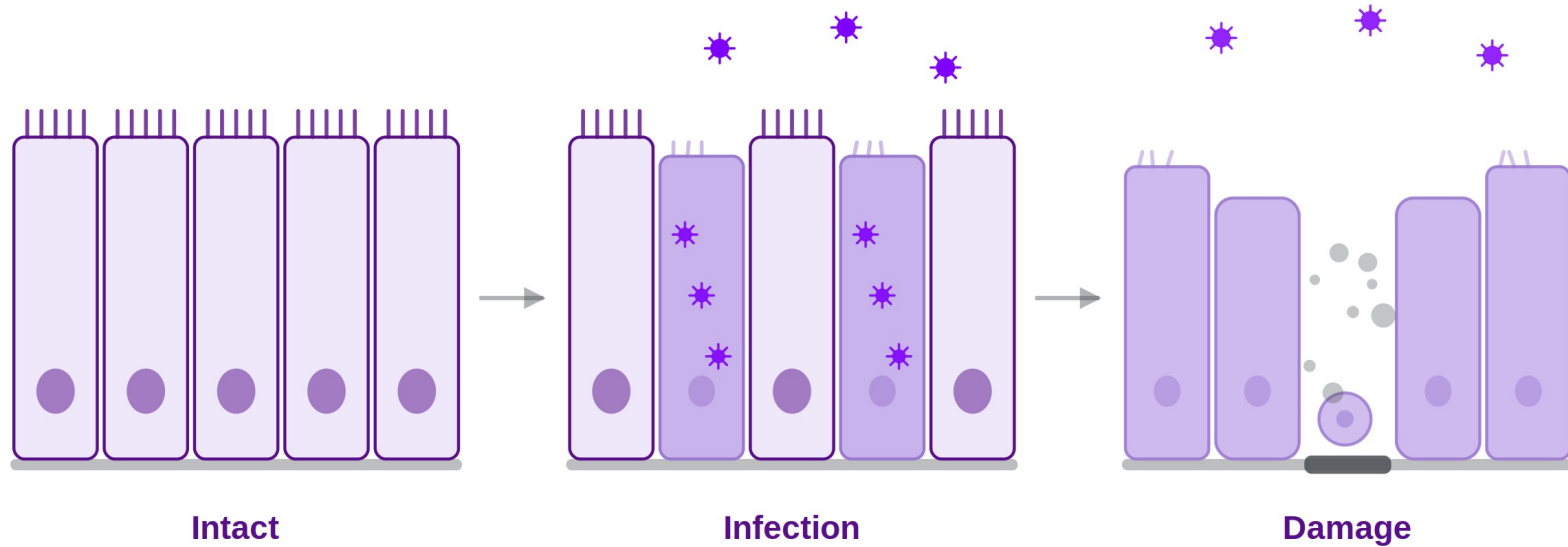
The response was also real.

People revealed capability, judgment, and loyalty that might otherwise have stayed invisible. That belongs to them. It does not belong to the thing that provoked it.

**We see versions of this
in biology.**

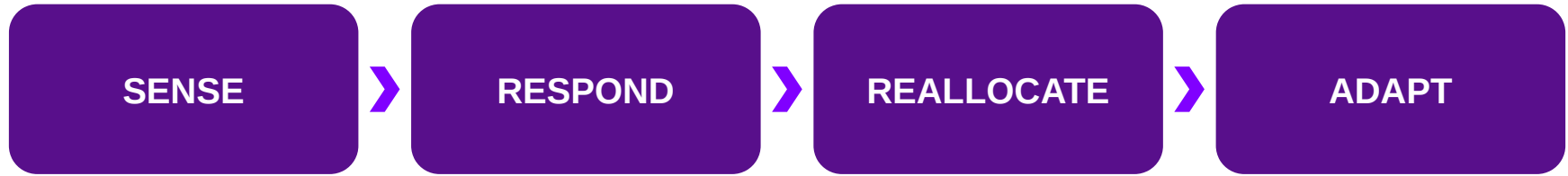
The Pathogen Is Not a Gift Either

The threat is real. The damage is real. Nothing about the response makes the infection worth having.



But the System Is Not Passive

It senses, responds, reallocates, and adapts, and it does that while the threat is still present.



The response is costly. It is also the reason the system is still standing.

Trained Immunity

One infection can leave the system better defended against an unrelated one.

A parasite

A real parasitic infection.
Pathology felt

Weeks later

The infection is cleared.
The tissue is repaired

Then a lethal flu

A different pathogen entirely. Every
unexposed control died but...

Every conditioned mouse survived.

Damani-Yokota et al., Khanna lab · accepted at Nature, August 2026

**The threat doesn't get the credit.
The response does.**

Which Brings Me to the Last Eighteen Months

It would be disingenuous to give this address without naming what everyone in this room has been carrying.

TheUpshot

**The U.S. Is
Funding Fewer
Grants in Every
Area of S
and Medi**

***Pace of N.I.H. Funding
Slows Further in Trump's
Second Year***

The agency has approved far fewer

The New York Times

***White House Moves
to Take Control of
N.I.H. Grants***

Federal officials are drafting an
executive order that would place

On Policy Alone, This Should Have Been a Lost Year

Less money, fewer students, smaller ambitions, and a lot of people quietly deciding to wait it out.

Graduate school admissions cut

Spending bill passed, awards didn't follow

NIH's priorities/policies rapidly change

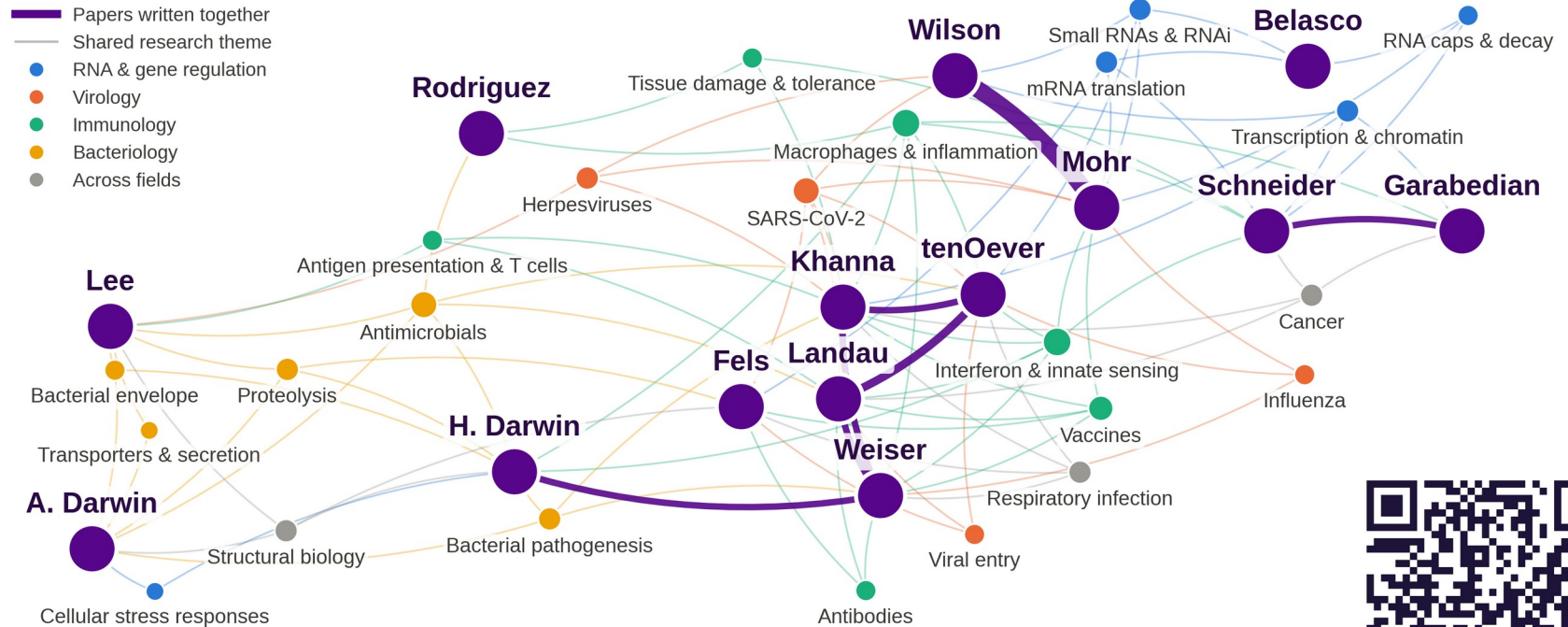
~10% loss of US scientific community

But that is not what happened here.

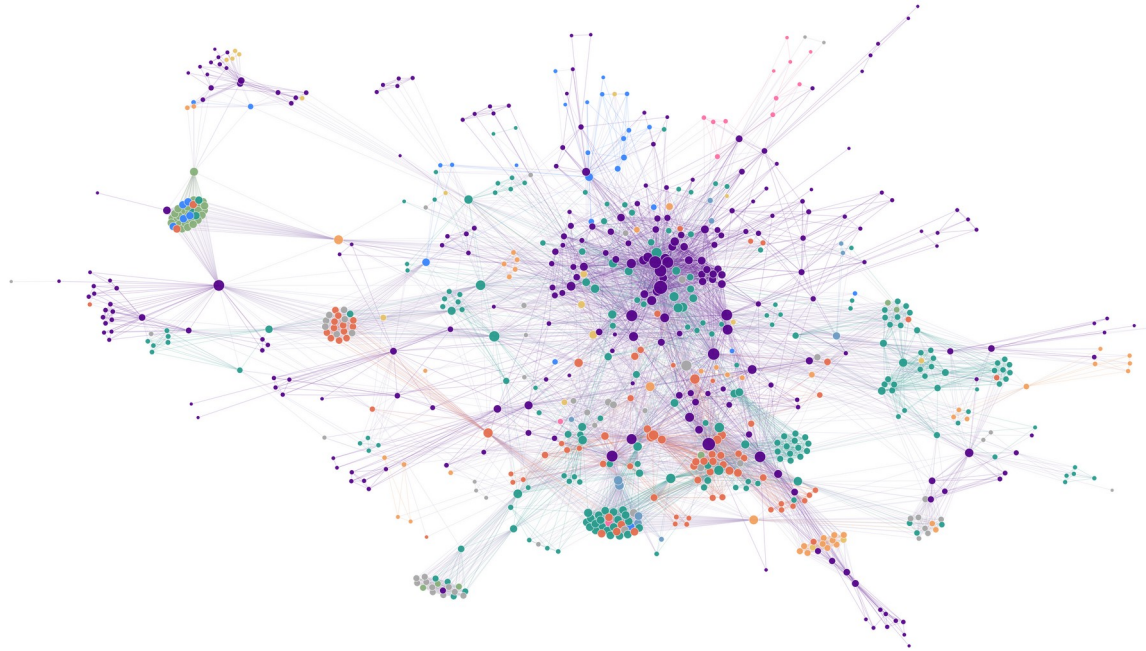
I would like to believe the reason is this:

a problem we all shared made us work as one department, not a collection of individual labs

Already Connected, but Not Yet Finished



Whatever Comes Next, There is Strength in Numbers



754 people on 331 shared papers
(PubMed, 2022-2026)

- Microbiology
- Medicine
- Pathology
- Biochemistry & Mol. Pharmacology
- Cell Biology
- Surgery
- Inst. for Systems Genetics
- Pediatrics
- Population Health
- Other departments & centers

**What the people in this
department actually did.**

Blue Ridge NIH Ranking

Among microbiology departments nationally.

25th → 16th

Nine places, in the single worst year for federal research funding in most of our careers.

That Ranking Did Not Move on Its Own

Twenty-four new awards have come into this department since my last annual departmental address.

24

new awards

10

laboratories

10

new R01s

Ten of faculty brought in new money in the two years everyone was told to expect the opposite.

Half From NIH, Half From Everywhere Else

In a year when the federal picture narrowed, this department widened where its support comes from.

12

NIH faculty awards

- 10 new R01s
- 1 R37 MERIT award
- 1 DP2 New Innovator award

7

Sponsors beyond NIH

- ARPA-H
- Cystic Fibrosis Foundation
- Merck
- Breast Cancer Research Foundation
- American Heart Association
- Flu Lab
- Global Health Fund Initiative

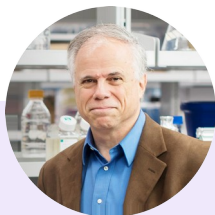
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Trainee awards & honors

- Dounia Abbadi, PhD**
Novo Nordisk BioInnovation Award
- Alberto Canfrán-Duque, PhD**
AHA Fellowship
- Vinica Dhar, PhD**
Bernard Levine Fellowship in Immunology
- Sydney Pimentel**
F30, MD/PhD candidate
- Leon Hsieh, PhD**
CTSI award
- Adam Silhavy**
Speaker, vEM Forum, Beijing

Controlling the Message

Belasco · Garabedian · Schneider - the control points of gene expression, from bacteria to cancer to muscle.



J. Belasco, PhD

**Three senior-author papers
on RNA caps**

NAR and PNAS - plus two in
Nature Chemical Biology with
collaborators.



M. Garabedian, PhD

**Two new R01s, the second
this month**

The September award is with Ryan
Branski; MDM2 and c-Myc
translational control in PNAS.



R. Schneider, PhD

A new R01 and paper

In Molecular Therapy this June.
Four new awards this year,
including the R01 and two from
BCRF.

Bacteria Under Pressure (2x Darwins, 2x 2026 Awardees)

A. Darwin · H. Darwin - envelope stress and regulated proteolysis.



A. Darwin, PhD

Basic Medical Sciences Educator Award

Two new R01s this year.



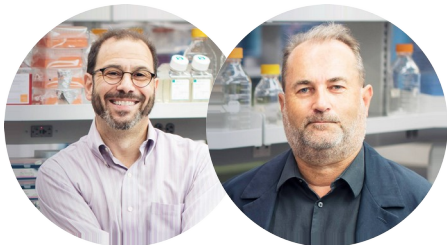
H. Darwin, PhD

ASM Award for Basic Research

Two new R01s and two papers in J. Bacteriology.

Two Laboratories That Chose Each Other

Two labs, one question - how herpesviruses persist. Twenty-one papers written together.



I. Mohr · A. Wilson

Shared students, shared benches, and the heaviest single link on the department map.

A joint Annual Review of Microbiology

On the shared strategies behind phage and herpesvirus persistence - the review neither lab would have written alone.

Herpes simplex virus fluidizes the nucleus

In Molecular Cell this March.

Herpesvirus poly(A) regulation

In PLoS Pathogens, alongside the m6A work on how the virus remodels host RNA.

Tolerance, Damage and Transmission

Khanna · Rodriguez · Weiser - how hosts withstand infection, and how pathogens spread.



K. Khanna, PhD

**Nature & Immunity
publications + a new R01**

Type 2 immune history trains lung
macrophages for viral disease
tolerance.



A. Rodriguez, PhD

**How malaria breaks the
blood-brain barrier**

Plasmodium-induced disruption of
brain endothelium, in Malaria
Journal.



J. Weiser, MD, PhD

**Eight senior-author papers
this year**

All on pneumococcal colonization -
and an R37 with Kamal.

Viruses as Targets, Sensors and Tools

Landau · Lee · tenOever - restriction, host sensing, and programmable viral platforms.



N. Landau, PhD

A new R01, and a Merck-funded program

Restriction factors and vector platforms, funded from two directions in the same year.



J. Lee, PhD

NIH Director's New Innovator Award

A DP2, in his first year running a lab here.



B. tenOever, PhD

Two New R01s and a paper

Plus a new hospital virus surveillance program.

And One More, Who Hasn't Started Yet

The newest member of this department will launch his new lab in the weeks ahead.



J. Maximilian Fels, PhD

Biology and immunology of giant viruses.

He arrives with a recent Cell paper about giant DNA viruses encoding their own eIF4F-like cap-binding complex.

Starting October 2026.

**Some of you lost grants.
Some of you lost people.
Some colleagues left the department
altogether.**

Collective resilience does not erase individual difficulty,
and I am not going to pretend otherwise.

...but both things can be true

The national picture is genuinely uncertain. The local picture is genuinely expanding. Neither one cancels the other.

Nationally

Federal funding, paylines, graduate admissions, and long-range planning all remain unpredictable. That is not going to resolve quickly.

Here

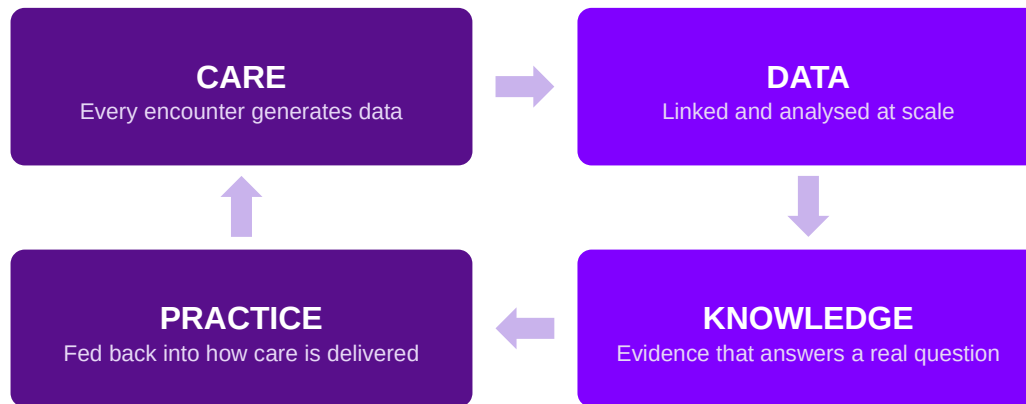
New leadership investing in basic science, a clinical interface, new programmatic growth, and the recruitment of new faculty ahead.

A New Dean, and a Renewed Bet on Basic Science

Alec C. Kimmelman, MD, PhD - Dean of the School of Medicine and CEO of NYU Langone Health.



THE LEARNING HEALTH SYSTEM



\$30 Million from Jan Vilcek

Additional support for students and for basic science.

\$30M

The gift matters. What it signals matters more: the institution values our graduate school.

The Clinical Interface Is Becoming Operational

Not rhetorical. Six efforts, every one of them started at a bench in this department.

Oncolytic immunotherapy

Ian Mohr

In a multicentre trial at nine sites worldwide, NYU among them. A second candidate is licensed to Omios Biologics.

TRACE — real-time viral surveillance

Michael Phillips · Ben tenOever

Respiratory pathogens linked to clinical samples, sequencing and hospital outcomes.

AUF1 gene therapy for muscle

Bob Schneider

Delivered by AAV or mRNA: blocks atrophy, restores strength. Molecular Therapy, June.

Targeting the androgen receptor

Michael Garabedian

A macrocyclic peptoid-peptide hybrid, with in vivo efficacy already published.

In vivo editing for xenotransplantation

Montgomery - tenOever · Boeke

A delivery platform under DARPA and BARDA - and the engine behind the new xenotransplantation program.

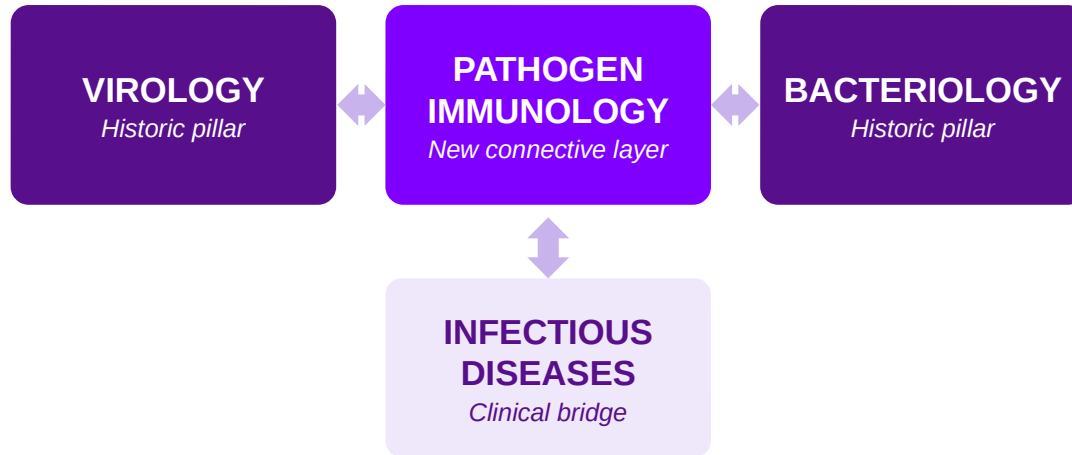
Pathogen Immunology Center

Kamal Khanna

Establishing a community of immunologists that are pathogen agnostic

Pathogen Immunology As a New Connective Layer

A pathogen-agnostic middle ground that ties our community together - and gives us a shared language with Infectious Diseases.



5

new faculty ahead

3 in pathogen immunology
2 in core microbiology disciplines

The Problem We Have in Common

I would argue that it was not a strategic plan that brought us together. It was a shared problem.

REALLOCATE

Money and equipment to where
they change outcomes

BUILD CAPABILITY

Shared resources any lab here
can reach

MOVE INFORMATION

Improve communication across
the community

Renovations Are (Almost) Finished

We have a dedicated Zoom room for small groups on the 5th floor, with 2 individual ones still to come beside it. We also have a new small conference room on the 4th floor. Lunch spaces are still awaiting final renovations.



4th floor Zoom room



5th floor conference room

lasco and both Darwin labs are now on the fifth floor, Landau lab is now on the fourth.

Every Shared Instrument, Now in One Place

24 instruments, 15 models

Across twelve rooms in both ACLS towers, each with a plain-language description of what it actually does.

Search it, or browse by floor

By name, vendor, application or room number - “ultracentrifuge”, “Western”, “ddPCR”, or just 431.

Six of them arrived this year

The Streamer shear system, the gentleMACS dissociator, the Vi-CELL, the ddPCR, the ZentriMix and an Avanti JXN-26.



Helping the Community Find Funding

One site for grants and awards at every career stage - faculty, postdocs and graduate students.

Faculty grants & awards

Open federal and foundation calls, each matched to a team, with a working title, aims, and who might own each one

Postdoctoral fellowships

Every recurring program, with its eligibility window, citizenship rule and next deadline, including nomination-only awards

Graduate student fellowships

Most are decided in the first two years. Predoctoral fellowships, prizes and travel awards



The Quarterly Newsletter

Now in its second year, it is a valuable resource for the community to stay connected.



Quarterly newsletter highlighting the Department of Microbiology at NYU Langone



Editor:
Judy Minkoff
tenOever lab



Assistant Editor:
Emily Dembinski
Ratner lab

Every Lab Has a Liaison

The people who carry information in both directions - and the reason the newsletter has anything in it.



Joel Belasco
Belasco Lab



Andrew Darwin
A. Darwin Lab



Ryan Gado
H. Darwin Lab



Max Fels
Fels Lab



Rachel Ruoff
Garabedian Lab



Vinica Dhar
Khanna Lab



Leo Semana
Landau Lab



James Lee
Lee Lab



Adam Silhavy
Mohr/Wilson Lab



Stacey Bartlett
Ortigoza Lab



Alejandro Pironti
Pironti Lab



Emily Dembinski
Ratner Lab



Marilyn Vasquez
Rodriguez Lab



Erin Zwack
Schneider Lab



Alice Tillman
Shopsin Lab



Ryla Cantergiani
tenOever Lab



Jeffrey Weiser
Weiser Lab

And If You Would Rather Tell Me Yourself



I should not be making decisions about this department without regularly hearing from the people living in it. That is what the trainee lunches are for — every other month. Come.

The Seminar Series Is How We Widen the Circle

New room, new day, and lunch instead of coffee and cookies.

Wednesdays, 12:30-1:30

The new dedicated room on the fourth floor

Lunch is served

Another reason to come support your community

Everyone hosts

1-3/year/lab, plus slots for students, postdocs, and the extended community

The Whole Year Is Online, and It Is Not Finished

Forty-three sessions. Sixteen speakers confirmed. Nineteen dates still waiting for a host.

It is a living document

Slots get traded, speakers get confirmed, defenses get booked. The page re-reads itself every time you open it - it knows which seminar is next.

The empty slots are an invitation

Five dates have no host at all. Bring in someone you have wanted to hear from, or give somebody in your lab the floor. You do not need to be asked.

Book your defense into this hour

If you are defending this year, take one of these slots. The room is booked and the department is already coming.



Two Clubs, and Anyone Can Walk In

No membership and no invitation needed. Both meet in ACLS-West, room 508.

Virology Consortium

Every other Tuesday, 10:30 - 11:30

Running now. The standing forum for virology across the department and beyond it.

RNA Club

First Thursdays, 5:00 pm - from November

New this year, led by Phoebe Chen and Morgane Baldaccini, PhD.

ACLS-West, room 508 · Students, postdocs, staff and faculty - from any department.

Add These in Your Calendar

The year has a shape. Most of it is already booked.



The departmental retreat

May 2027

The holiday party

Friday, December 4, 2026, at Apella

The seminar series, every Wednesday

12:30, fourth floor, lunch provided

Lunches with students and postdocs

Every other month

The newsletter, quarterly

Your liaison is where its content comes from

And the People Who Actually Run This Department

None of what we just covered happens without them.

Nina Umerah

Department Administrator

Jennifer Pagano

Program Manager
Faculty affairs and events.

Mereme Mulkurtaj

Associate Director of Finance and Administration
Post-award lead — grants, budgets and spend plans.

Cesar Ruiz

Senior Program Coordinator
Departmental operations; ordering for AMR

Alan Cheng

Administrative Coordinator
Immigration for new arrivals;
ordering/reconciliation for all labs except Lee, Fels, Landau, and tenOever.

Fatema Rahman

Executive Assistant to the Chair
Seminar series scheduling and speaker coordination.

Faina Shenfeld

Senior Financial Analyst
Post-award finance, with Mereme.

Claudia Donnerhack

Pre-Award Specialist
Grant submissions and progress reports.

Keisha Brooks

Project Coordinator
Hiring and onboarding; ordering/reconciliation for the Lee, Fels and Landau labs.

**This year does not get the credit
for our success.**

We do.



Thank you

Hope to see everyone at the reception at 4pm on the fifth floor later this afternoon.



Landing page for all resources